

Antoni Gaudí

The unique style of Catalan architect Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926) blends art nouveau and modernism with myriad other elements and influences, including Catalan and Moorish traditions, the Gothic revival and his own devout Catholic beliefs. His fluid lines and asymmetrical shapes convey a focus on natural motifs, with textured and undulating forms that recall the sea, coral, fish, dragons and lizards, as well as sinuous curves designed to glitter in the sun as the day passes. Structures such as Casa Mila (1906–10), Casa Batlló (1904, opposite) and Parc Güell (established 1914) feature unusual tracery, few straight lines, irregularly shaped windows and façades made of *trencadís*: a mosaic of colourful ceramic tile pieces. Casa Batlló's roof, for instance, resembles the back of a dragon, with balcony balustrades shaped like eye masks, and 'scales' of glistening *trencadís*; Parc Güell features colourful mosaic surfaces and a Doric colonnade. Gaudí's approach to architecture was always sculptural, with a perpetual dynamism deriving from his endlessly curving lines.

